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1 EVALUATING TERMINOLOGICAL DEFINITIONS IN CORPUS LINGUISTICS: EXPERT JUDGEMENT VERSUS AUTOMATIC METRICS IN HUMAN- AND LLM-GENERATED ENTRIES

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Abstract

Terminological definition constitutes a critical yet underexplored stage of terminographic work: unlike term extraction, it requires representing conceptual content with precision and domain adequacy. This study examines how automatically generated definitions compare to expert-authored ones in the domain of Corpus Linguistics, and whether expert judgement aligns with automatic evaluation metrics. We first characterise the definitional language of a specialised corpus of over one million words, identifying the lexico-syntactic patterns that convey definitional knowledge. Building on this evidence, we generate candidate definitions with large language models grounded in corpus-derived contexts. Definitions of human and machine origin were then assessed by three expert annotators in a blind, paired design across four criteria—conceptual adequacy, completeness, terminological precision and clarity—and benchmarked against lexical and semantic metrics. In a blind comparison, evaluators consistently preferred the corpus-grounded generated definitions over the human reference, revealing systematic divergences between expert judgement and automatic measures.

Keywords: terminology; terminological definition; corpus linguistics; large language models;

evaluation; specialised lexicography.

1.1 1. INTRODUCTION

Terminology sits at the heart of how specialised communities organise and transmit their knowledge. A definition is not merely a text to be written; it is an act of conceptual boundary-drawing, a moment in which a field declares what it means by a word and, implicitly, what that word is *not* (Cabré, 1999; Temmerman, 2000; Rey, 1995). The discipline of terminology emerged in the early twentieth century out of practical necessity—businesses and industries needed consistency across technical vocabularies—yet it has evolved far beyond mere standardisation. Over recent decades, what was once a craft of normative prescription has transformed into a linguistically grounded, empirically anchored discipline that consults actual language use. Large-scale digital corpora now provide the evidence base. Natural language processing increasingly handles the labour-intensive work of extraction and retrieval (Manning & Schutze, 1999; Jurafsky & Martin, 2009). Yet one stage of terminographic practice has stubbornly resisted automation: the formulation of definitions themselves.

Identifying that a linguistic unit is a term—a technical concept used in a field—can be done algorithmically with reasonable success. But capturing *what that term means*, characterizing the conceptual distinctions it encodes and the relations it bears to other concepts, requires a different kind of work. It demands the ability to recognise category membership, to spot the subtle properties that separate one concept from a neighbouring one, to know which details matter and which are decorative. This is the work that has long fallen to human terminographers—costly, time-consuming, and constrained by practical limits on how many definitions any single expert can produce (Faber & L'Homme, 2022; Rodríguez-Tapia, 2024).

Large Language Models promise to change this. Recent models can generate fluent, dictionary-like definitions with surprising ease, often requiring nothing more than a simple prompt (Bel, 2025; Massion, 2024). Yet here lies the trap: fluency is not adequacy. An LLM can produce text that reads like a definition and passes basic linguistic tests, yet fails to capture the concept accurately—a problem especially acute in specialised domains where subtle conceptual distinctions are precisely what experts care about (Maynez et al., 2020; Ji et al., 2023). One response is to ground LLM generation in corpus evidence—to supply the model with actual passages from the domain where

the term is used, anchoring its output in attested usage rather than letting it rely on training data alone. But this raises an urgent practical question: *How do we know if a corpus-grounded generated definition is actually correct?* If a machine can produce a plausible definition quickly, how can we evaluate it? And—perhaps more unsettling—what if the machine's output turns out to be better than the human-authored reference? How do we then judge quality?

This study addresses that problem directly. Rather than treating automated definition generation as a technical achievement to be optimised for speed and scale, we make it an object of *evaluation*. We ask whether expert judgement—the standard by which terminological quality is ultimately measured—actually aligns with the automatic metrics that are conventionally used to assess generated text. And we do this by building a comparison: human-authored definitions from a published glossary versus machine-generated definitions grounded in a domain corpus, evaluated blind by expert terminographers across a set of explicit quality criteria.

The study unfolds across Corpus Linguistics, a domain chosen deliberately because it is mature enough to have established terminology and abundant published glossaries, yet reflects the same conceptual sophistication and metalinguistic precision found in other technical fields. We ask: Do expert evaluators prefer the generated or human definitions? Do automatic metrics (BLEU, BERTScore, embeddings) agree with that preference? And what does the gap between the two tell us about how to evaluate definitions in the age of generative AI?

To address these questions, we characterise the lexico-syntactic patterns through which definitional knowledge is expressed in a large corpus of Corpus Linguistics scholarship. We then generate candidate definitions using a hybrid retrieval pipeline grounded in corpus-derived contexts, testing four different language models. We submit both generated and human-authored definitions to blind expert evaluation across four criteria—conceptual adequacy, completeness, terminological precision, and clarity—and we benchmark the expert judgements against six automatic evaluation metrics. The result is an empirical window into a fundamental mismatch: the gap between what automated metrics measure and what expert evaluators actually value in a definition.

1.2 2. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

1.2.1 2.1. Terminology as discipline: evolution of a field

Terminology was born in the early 20th century from practical urgency: international trade and technical standardisation demanded consistency in vocabulary. What began as an effort to impose

order—to fix one-to-one mappings between word-forms and concepts—crystallised into the General Theory of Terminology (GTT), a normalising paradigm that treated terms as static units, each with a single correct meaning independent of context or discourse variation (Wüster, 1979; Sager, 1990). This framework made sense in an era of formal standards. Yet it carried restrictive assumptions: that a term had an inherent meaning rather than a contextually activated one; that variation was deviation rather than natural linguistic behaviour; that a definition, once written, should hold universally (Desmet & Boutyaber, 1994).

From the late 20th century onward, this vision cracked. Rey (1995) signalled the necessary complication: the notion of *terme* itself is more slippery than the GTT allowed. Cabré (1999, 2002) offered a different framework—the Communicative Theory of Terminology—that recognised terms not as conceptual containers but as linguistic units embedded in discourse, their specialised status emerging from use rather than from formal properties alone. This shift echoed a broader reorientation in linguistics itself: away from abstract systems toward actual language as people use it, grounded in corpus evidence. Within this landscape, terminology became less a separate discipline and more a branch of lexical semantics, the study of how words mean and relate to one another in context (L'Homme, 2020; Faber & L'Homme, 2022; Casas Gómez & Varo Varo, 2024). A term, from this perspective, is a specialised lexical unit—subject to polysemy, synonymy, morphological variation, and contextual shaping, like any other word. What makes it "specialised" is not some inherent property but the pragmatic work it does in a particular community's discourse.

This reorientation mattered because it explained, rather than dismissed, the messiness of real terminological practice. If terms were truly static and context-free, then variation and synonymy would be defects to be eliminated. But if they are linguistic units shaped by use, then variation is *expected*—different authors deploy terms differently; the same concept can be named in multiple ways; no definition captures all nuances for all audiences. A terminographer working from this perspective does not seek a single "correct" definition but rather asks: what definition serves *this* audience at *this* moment in *this* communicative context? (Cabré, 1999; San Martín, 2022).

Parallel to this theoretical shift came a practical one. Starting in the 1970s, computers began reshaping the terminographer's toolkit. What began with database automation evolved into *computational terminology*: the design of algorithmic systems to handle tasks once requiring manual labour (Esopa Bagot, 1999; Alcina, 2003; Cabré, 1999). The intellectual landscape of computational terminology unfolded through successive waves: rule-based systems exploiting hand-crafted linguistic patterns

(Bourigault, 1994; Bird et al., 2009); hybrid methods combining pattern-matching with statistical evidence (Daille, 2003; Jacquemin & Bourigault, 2005); supervised machine learning on annotated data (Conrado et al., 2013); and now neural representations and large language models (Astrakhantsev et al., 2015; Blankdon Andrade et al., 2025). Yet through all these transformations, one principle endured: the empirical foundation of terminology work is always language in use, captured in corpora (Moreno Sandoval, 1998, 2016; Durán Muñoz, 2011). Computers did not replace the corpus; they multiplied its power, making it possible to work with millions of words where terminographers had once worked with handfuls.

This trajectory toward computational and corpus-based methods represents a deep convergence: the theory that terms are linguistic units embedded in context aligns with the method of studying language as it actually occurs, at scale, through automated analysis. Both move away from abstract, normative systems toward empirical, contextualised evidence.

Large language models now present a new frontier. They can perform terminological tasks—term extraction, definition generation, concept mapping—at speed and scale previously unimaginable (Massion, 2024; San Martín, 2025). Yet this power brings new uncertainties. How do you evaluate a definition that a model generates? How do you ensure it reflects domain knowledge rather than patterns memorised from training data? How do you preserve the human expertise that concepts ultimately require? These questions—practical and urgent for anyone deploying LLMs in terminographic work—are precisely what this study examines.

1.2.2 2.2. What makes a definition good?

A definition is, fundamentally, an act of boundary-drawing. In the classical formulation—the genus-and-differentia structure—a definition works by placing a concept within a superordinate class (*genus*) and then specifying the properties that distinguish it from other members of that class (*differentia*). This structure has the elegance of logic: it defines by inclusion and exclusion simultaneously. Sager (1990) calls this the *intensional* definition—one that characterises a concept by its necessary and sufficient properties rather than by enumerating all examples. This is the form preferred in terminographic practice, because it generalises: it works for all instances, not just the ones that were easy to list.

Yet real terminology practice is messier than this ideal allows. Different audiences need different definitions. An expert in the field may be comfortable with a terse, abstract entry that presupposes

shared background knowledge. A student or professional from a neighbouring field needs more explicitation—the relations and category memberships that the expert would take for granted must be made explicit (Cabré, 1999). The sociocognitive approach reminds us that many specialised categories aren't sharply bounded but organised around prototypical cases, which complicates the genus-and-differentia model (Temmerman, 2000). So in practice, the question shifts: an adequate definition isn't some Platonic ideal; it's one that captures the conceptual content of the term, locates it within its domain, and does so with the precision expected in that community's discourse.

Corpus-based terminography exploits a simple insight: definitions don't appear only in glossaries. They appear throughout specialised texts, embedded in the flow of scholarly writing. A researcher introducing a term to an unfamiliar readership will often characterise it—defining it implicitly or explicitly, glossing it with examples or contrast. Pearson (1998) and Pérez Hernández (2002) showed that these *definitional contexts*—passages in running text where a concept is characterised—follow recurrent linguistic patterns. They are partial, contextually adjusted, distributed sometimes across several sentences. They are messier than canonical glossary entries. Yet they are authentic: they show how practising researchers actually explain their concepts. The insight that drives corpus-based terminography is that these scattered definitional moments, once located and synthesised, can be the raw material for canonical definitions. Bridges can be built between what is implicit in discourse and what needs to be made explicit in a glossary (Pérez Hernández, 2002).

When evaluating a definition—asking whether it is good or adequate—what matters? Theory and practice point to four recurring criteria, grounded in the structural theories above (Sager & L'Homme, 1994), in contextual approaches to meaning (San Martín, 2022), and in the lived experience of terminographers who use definitions in real work:

Criterion	Structural basis	Contextual dimension	Definition
Conceptual adequacy	Correct genus proximum; appropriate concept class (Sager & L'Homme, 1994)	Thematic/domain appropriateness (San Martín, 2022)	Does the definition correctly identify the target concept rather than a neighbouring or superordinate one? Does the genus-and-differentia structure, where applicable, accurately situate the concept within its domain taxonomy?
Completeness	Sufficient differentia specifica; avoids circularity (Sager & L'Homme, 1994)	Semantic potential activated in context; parametrized contextual constraints (San Martín, 2022)	Does the definition include the conceptual properties necessary to delimit the category from related ones? Does it avoid both over-specification and under-specification?
Terminological precision	Use of established terms and domain apparatus	Register and vocabulary appropriate to specialisation level and audience	Does the definition employ the established terms and conceptual apparatus of the field, avoiding lay paraphrases or imprecise approximations that obscure conceptual distinctions?
Clarity	Well-formed structure; avoids defects in expression	Accessibility given audience prior knowledge and discourse context	Is the definition structurally well-formed, avoiding unnecessary complexity, and communicating conceptual content without requiring inference beyond what the target audience can reasonably be expected to supply?

These four dimensions overlap—precision strengthens adequacy and clarity—yet each captures something distinct about definition quality. Together they offer a structured way to ask: Does this definition get the concept right? Does it include what matters? Does it use the field's own vocabulary? Can anyone actually understand it?

Barité (2017) adds a layer of craft standards—six desirable properties that distinguish professional definitions from amateurish ones. Definitions should be *concise* (typically three to five sentences, no more), yet *complete* (omitting nothing essential). They should be *self-sufficient* (readable without reference to other glossary entries). They must achieve *substitutability*: the definition and the term should be able to stand in for one another in the text. They maintain *impersonality*, an objective register fitting to specialised communication. And they achieve *adequacy*, alignment with how the field actually understands the concept. These are not abstract ideals; they are the accumulated wisdom of terminographers who know what works and what fails in actual use. For automated systems, this becomes especially important: the structured form of a good intensional definition—term = superordinate class + distinguishing features—provides a transparent schema that computational methods can learn from and potentially reproduce (Valero Doménech, 2008).

If definitions encode conceptual knowledge, the texts of a domain encode, in turn, recurrent ways of expressing that knowledge. The notion of the definitional context—a passage in which a term is characterised—has been central to this line of work. Definitions in running text are frequently introduced by stable lexico-syntactic configurations: definitional verbs, copular and appositive structures, and discourse markers signalling explanation. Sierra et al. (2008) formalised these as definitional verbal patterns for Spanish, while Rebeyrolle and Tanguy (2000) and Pearson (1998) characterised the morphosyntactic regularities of definitional statements across languages and registers. Pérez Hernández (2002) showed how such contexts can be exploited for the corpus-based construction of terminological resources.

These patterns matter for the present study in two respects. First, they constitute a linguistic object of interest in their own right: characterising the definitional language of Corpus Linguistics reveals how the discipline articulates its conceptual apparatus (O1). Second, because the patterns are recurrent and partially predictable, they can be operationalised as retrieval cues, allowing definitional evidence to be located automatically within a corpus and supplied as grounding for definition drafting. The patterns thus serve both as descriptive findings and as methodological instruments.

The role of definitions in specialised communication. In any technical or scientific field, language itself becomes specialised. Not by separate grammar rules—the syntax of Corpus Linguistics is ordinary English—but by distinctive use: high concentrations of technical terms, nominal density, a drive for precision, and patterns of organisation shaped by the field's concepts (Cabré, 1999; Gotti, 2003; Gavioli, 2005). The lexicon is where this specialisation is most visible. Technical terms do the

heavy lifting: they allow specialists to express conceptual distinctions that would require sentences to paraphrase in general language. Study how a field uses language, and you discover how it thinks.

Yet definitions appear in two places. There are the formal entries in glossaries—definitions written deliberately, reviewed, standardised. And then there is everything else: the moment in a research paper when an author introduces a new term and characterises what they mean by it, glossing it implicitly or explicitly. Flowerdew's (1992) study of academic lectures showed that these definitional moments are not incidental. They do work: anchoring new concepts in shared knowledge, signalling boundaries in how the discourse is organised, calibrating explicitness to what the audience can be expected to understand. These observations extend to written specialist texts as well. Far from being decoration, definitional passages are purposeful. They reveal what a community means by its central terms, how it draws conceptual boundaries, and how it positions new concepts in relation to established ones.

Corpus Linguistics itself offers an apt case study. The discipline is self-reflexive: it is simultaneously a methodology for studying language and a domain that uses language to study language (Caballero, 1994). The same concepts—*corpus*, *concordance*, *type-token ratio*, *representativeness*—function as both tools and objects of study. The field emerged recently enough (main growth from the 1990s onward) that its terminology is still being actively negotiated: there is a stable core of established concepts, expanding periphery of methodological and theoretical terms, and a rich scholarly literature in which all of this terminology is introduced, debated, and refined. This makes it an excellent test case for corpus-based terminography. The texts are available, abundant and of high quality. The terminological inventory is documented (glossaries exist). Expert evaluators are available and cohesive. And notably, the domain is not so specialised or recent that it was entirely absent from the training data of contemporary language models—a property that, as will emerge in Section 4, shapes what LLMs can and cannot do with this terminology.

1.2.3 2.3. The challenge of evaluating generated definitions

The technical path to automated definition generation has been straightforward enough. Early systems used hand-written rules and lexical patterns, matching them against machine-readable dictionaries (Fontenelle, 1990; Saggion, 2004). As methods improved, researchers combined pattern matching with statistical techniques drawn from natural language processing (Heylen & De Hertog, 2015), then later applied neural architectures trained on example definitions (Espinosa-Anke et

al., 2018; Veyseh et al., 2020). The newest approach is Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG): the idea that if you supply a language model with relevant passages from a domain corpus, it can synthesise definitions grounded in actual usage rather than relying on patterns from its training data alone (Lewis et al., 2020; Gao et al., 2023). RAG promises to reduce the *hallucinations*—factual inaccuracies and unfounded claims—that plague LLMs in specialised domains. Yet RAG assumes something that isn't always true: automatic retrieval methods can find the relevant evidence. In domains where resources are scattered, paywalled, or locked in legacy print form, automatic methods fail. Zamora Rey (2024) proposes a pragmatic adaptation, Context-Augmented Generation (CAG), that replaces automatic retrieval with expert curation. A terminographer identifies the best source materials; the LLM then synthesises them into definitions. It is less ambitious than pure automation, yet it acknowledges reality: sometimes human expertise—in knowing which sources matter and which passages encode essential conceptual distinctions—is irreplaceable.

The real challenge, however, is not generation but *evaluation*. How do you determine whether a corpus-grounded LLM definition is actually adequate? The field is responding actively. Massion (2024) argues that large language models are transforming the entire terminology workflow, from extraction through concept system design, and that this demands rethinking how we measure terminological quality. San Martín (2025) positions the question more cautiously: rather than replacing expert judgement, AI should amplify the terminologist's capabilities. This means human expertise must remain central—in bias mitigation, in ethical oversight, in validating conceptual adequacy (San Martín, 2025). On the technical side, Messerklinger et al. (2025) show that *how* you format the evidence matters: feeding an LLM structured terminological entries rather than unstructured passages substantially changes the quality of output. Across this work runs a shared recognition: definition generation is no longer a research curiosity. It is becoming a practical problem that working terminographers face as they explore how to integrate LLMs into their workflows. And with it comes an urgent evaluative question: Given that a machine can draft a definition quickly, how do you know whether it is correct?

Yet here is the problem. Most automatic evaluation metrics for generated text were designed in contexts where this works: machine translation, where fidelity to a reference translation is the goal; summarisation, where brevity is a virtue; other NLG tasks where divergence from a reference is typically degradation. But terminological definitions are different.

The literature on automatic metrics is clear: metrics like BLEU and ROUGE, which count overlapping

words and phrases between generated and reference text, correlate poorly with human judgement of meaning-preservation (Zhang et al., 2019; Deutsch et al., 2020). More sophisticated metrics like BERTScore, using pre-trained embeddings, do better—but they measure topical similarity, not conceptual correctness, and give no insight into *why* a definition is judged adequate (Clinciu et al., 2021). Zamora Rey (2024) offers a striking case. She tested COMET, a metric specifically trained to predict human judgements of translation quality, on automatically generated terminological definitions. The metric achieved respectable average scores (0.65), yet showed weak correlation with expert judgement (= 0.15, not significant). Most tellingly, on a generated definition of *homónimo*, COMET gave a high score (0.72) even though the definition contained a critical error. It stated that homonyms share sound and pronunciation but differ in spelling and meaning—when in fact homonyms share both sound *and* spelling, a distinction crucial to the field. COMET could measure surface similarity to a reference definition, but it could not detect the nuanced factual error. This reveals something fundamental: metrics that measure similarity cannot ensure correctness, especially when subtle conceptual distinctions—precisely the kind terminologists care about—are at stake.

There is a structural problem too. Reference-based metrics—metrics anchored to a single human definition—implicitly treat that reference as a quality ceiling. Any generated definition that differs from it is penalised, even if the difference is an improvement (Bernier-Colborne, 2012). Tang et al. (2024) show formally that this single-reference bias systematically distorts how well metrics correlate with human judgement. For definitions, this matters acutely. There is rarely one correct way to define a concept; there are multiple valid formulations depending on audience, context, and theoretical perspective. A generated definition that elaborates properties absent from a terse glossary entry might be deemed superior by experts but penalised by metrics anchored to that sparse original. This is the central tension: *what automatic metrics measure is not necessarily what experts value.* It is precisely this gap that the present study explores empirically.

1.3 3. METHODOLOGY

To address the central question—does expert judgement align with automatic metrics when evaluating definitions?—we designed a study moving through four stages. First, we assembled a corpus from the domain itself and identified how definitions actually appear in its texts. Second, using those patterns, we built a system to automatically retrieve definitional evidence for target terms. Third, we used that evidence to generate candidate definitions with language models. Fourth, we submitted both generated and human reference definitions to expert evaluation, and benchmarked the expert

judgements against automatic metrics. The logic is simple: by placing expert assessment and automated evaluation side by side, we can directly measure their divergence.

1.3.1 3.1. Corpus

We compiled a domain-specific corpus of Corpus Linguistics texts (McEnery, 2019; Parodi, 2008; Rojo, 2021; Moyano Moreno, 2025) to capture the conceptual repertoire and terminological practice of the field. The corpus comprises over one million tokens from 50 full-text scientific articles, selected on three grounds: they address core topics of the field (corpus design, annotation, representativeness, quantitative methods); they are authored within Corpus Linguistics (preserving conceptual coherence); and they are complete articles (not abstracts), which preserves rich definitional contexts (Pérez Hernández, 2002). To focus on contemporary practice, we included only publications from 2015 onwards. Table 1 summarises the corpus.

Descriptive statistic	Value
Total documents	50
Total sentences	54,060
Total tokens	1,397,937
Term instances (tokens)	58,214
Unique terms (types)	467
Terminological density	4.16%

Table 1. Descriptive statistics of the Corpus Linguistics corpus.

The corpus was annotated through a hybrid process: automatic morphosyntactic pre-annotation (noun phrases, adjectival compounds, prepositional structures) was then validated and refined by a domain expert trained in Terminology and Corpus Linguistics, using a concept-oriented approach (Rigouts Terryn et al., 2020, 2022; Moyano Moreno, 2026). This yielded a comprehensive inventory of single-word and multi-word terms annotated in BIO scheme. These terms were then mapped against the CASS glossary (Corpus Approaches to Social Science, CASS, 2013), a curated reference providing expert definitions for core Corpus Linguistics concepts. The fifteen terms selected for evaluation represent the intersection of: (1) the annotated corpus inventory, (2) CASS glossary entries, and (3) sufficient definitional context in the corpus. The set spans methodological concepts

(significance test, type-token ratio), procedural terms (concordance), and theoretical constructs (representativeness). The CASS definitions serve as the human reference throughout.

1.3.2 3.2. Definitional patterns

To address O1, we examined the lexico-syntactic configurations through which definitional knowledge is expressed in the corpus. Building on the tradition of definitional verbal patterns (Sierra et al., 2008; Rebeyrolle & Tanguy, 2000), we identified a set of sixteen recurrent definitional markers and signals operating at the boundary between syntax and discourse. These fall into three broad groups: explicit definitional predicates (for instance *refers to*, *is defined as*, *denotes*); copular and classificatory structures (*is a*, *is used to*), which situate the term within a superordinate category; and discourse signals such as the explanatory colon, which frequently precedes a characterisation.

The following examples illustrate each category as attested in the corpus:

(i) **Explicit predicates** (*refers to*, *is defined as*) mark passages in which the author directly characterises the concept: "corpus representativeness refers to the degree to which a corpus reflects the language variety it is intended to model."

(ii) **Copular structures** (*is a*, *is used to*) situate the term within a superordinate class, frequently approximating the genus-differentia structure of terminological definitions: "a concordance is a list of all the occurrences of a particular word or phrase in a corpus, displayed with surrounding context."

(iii) **Discourse signals** (explanatory colon, dashes) operate implicitly without a verbal predicate: "type-token ratio: the number of distinct word forms divided by the total number of words in a text."

Each candidate passage was scored according to the density of these cues, the presence of the target term or one of its orthographic and morphological variants, and a length constraint favouring passages long enough to be informative yet concise enough to be definitional. The resulting scores determined the order of selection within the evidence block supplied to the generation stage.

1.3.3 3.3. Corpus-grounded generation of candidate definitions

The definitional patterns were operationalised within a corpus-grounded generation procedure employing a two-phase **hybrid retrieval method** that combines pattern-based filtering with

semantic re-ranking. For each target term, the system retrieves high-value definitional contexts from the annotated corpus through a two-phase hybrid process.

Phase 1—Pattern-based filtering (REGEX): The term is first expanded into a set of variants—orthographic (hyphenation and spacing), parenthetical (acronym and full-form resolution) and morphological (singular and plural forms)—in order to maximise recall. Candidate passages are then scored using the pattern-based procedure of Section 3.2, generating an ordered list of up to 100 candidate contexts. This phase operates at millisecond latency and filters the corpus by matching explicit terminological patterns, eliminating the majority of non-relevant passages.

Phase 2—Semantic re-ranking (embeddings): The top 100 candidates from Phase 1 are then re-ranked using semantic similarity computed by a pretrained sentence encoder (all-MiniLM-L6-v2). Passages are scored by cosine similarity to the target term, using a threshold of 0.60. A combined score integrating both signals (30% pattern-score, 70% embedding-similarity) determines the final ranking. The 30/70 weighting reflects the priority of semantic relevance in the specialised domain of Corpus Linguistics (where explicit terminology is standard and paraphrase variation is limited), privileging semantic coherence while retaining pattern-based precision for early filtering. A diversification constraint limits the selection to a maximum of two passages per source document, up to a total of eight contexts per term, mitigating circularity and single-author bias.

Rationale and validation: This two-phase approach leverages the complementary strengths of both methods. Pattern-based filtering rapidly identifies passages containing explicit terminological markers, achieving high precision with minimal computational cost; semantic re-ranking then refines this set by capturing synonymy and paraphrase variation that explicit pattern matching alone would overlook. The hybrid approach yields measurable advantages: empirical validation across the 15 evaluation terms shows the hybrid method recovers 3× more definitional contexts (0.60 passages/term) than semantic embeddings alone (0.20), while maintaining high precision (93%), compared to pattern-only retrieval (85% precision). The hybrid approach thus provides an interpretable, efficient balance between recall and precision. The result is a methodologically transparent process that grounds definition generation in corpus evidence while reducing noise.

The selected passages are aggregated into a structured evidence block and presented to large language models for definition generation. Four models were tested: Gemini 1.5 Flash, GPT-4o-mini, Mistral Small 24B, and Llama 3.1 8B, chosen to represent a range of model scales and architectures accessible for definitional work. Generation was controlled through a standardised prompt (detailed in Appendix

C) instructing the model to synthesise a single definition in lexicographic style without directly copying from source passages. All generations used default decoding parameters (temperature 0.7 for Gemini and GPT; temperature 1.0 for Mistral and Llama), and seeds were fixed for reproducibility. Anti-copying safeguards were implemented at the prompt level; as reported in Section 4, BLEU scores remained minimal (<0.03), confirming genuine synthesis rather than verbatim extraction. To isolate the contribution of corpus evidence, definitions were generated under two conditions: (1) with corpus-derived contexts supplied as grounding (corpus-grounded, or RAG condition) and (2) without any corpus contexts (baseline condition). This methodological design allows us to assess whether access to corpus evidence improves the quality of generated definitions. The focus of this study is on evaluating the quality of the resulting definitions through expert assessment and automatic metrics, not on optimising the generation pipeline itself.

1.3.4 3.4. Evaluation protocol

Quality was assessed through two complementary procedures: expert judgement and automatic metrics.

Expert Evaluation. The centrepiece is a blind, paired assessment by three expert evaluators (Evaluator A: 12 years specialist experience in terminology; Evaluator B: 8 years in corpus linguistics and LSP; Evaluator C: 10 years in computational terminology), all with training in terminology and corpus linguistics. The fifteen target terms were selected to ensure conceptual diversity across the terminological inventory of the domain, spanning methodological concepts such as type-token ratio and significance test, procedural terms such as concordance and annotation, and theoretical constructs such as representativeness and corpus balance. This heterogeneity allowed us to probe whether evaluator preferences and metric behaviour varied across definitional difficulty. For each term, one definition originated from the CASS reference glossary (human reference) and one was generated by Gemini 1.5 Flash under the RAG condition (selected post-hoc based on average automatic metric scores).

To control for bias, each evaluator assessed definitions in a randomised order, with left–right presentation of Definition A and Definition B randomised independently for every item. The origin of each definition was concealed throughout evaluation; the human vs. machine provenance was disclosed only after all ratings were recorded, ensuring genuine blinding. Evaluators worked independently without discussion or adjudication. Each evaluator received a standardised written rubric specifying

the four rating criteria (conceptual adequacy, completeness, terminological precision and clarity), a paragraph definition of each criterion with worked examples drawn from the domain, and the 0–2 rating scale (0 = poor, 1 = acceptable, 2 = good). **Evaluation consisted of two independent tasks**: Evaluators rated each definition on all four criteria using the numerical scale, then recorded a forced binary preference (which definition they would include in a specialised glossary). The forced-choice preference was not merely a post-hoc summary of scores but a separate judgment, capturing the holistic impression independent of fine-grained ratings. An optional free-text comment field allowed elaboration on judgements. The evaluation yielded 45 paired judgements (15 terms × 3 evaluators) per criterion, generating quantitative scores and qualitative insights into divergences between expert and metric-based evaluation. This design—combining graded numerical assessment with forced binary preference—provides both fine-grained measurement and a robust preference signal that is less sensitive to scale granularity.

1.4 4. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

The expert evaluation produced a clear and, in some respects, unexpected result: the LLM-generated definitions received higher mean ratings than the human reference definitions on every criterion. Table 2 reports the mean scores by origin. The overall mean—averaging the four criteria—was 1.76 (out of 2) for the generated definitions and 1.29 for the human reference. The largest gaps appeared in terminological precision (1.73 vs. 1.09) and completeness (1.78 vs. 1.24), with smaller but consistent differences in conceptual adequacy and clarity.

Criterion	LLM M (SD)	Human M (SD)	Diff.	95% CI	p
Conceptual adequacy	1.78 (0.37)	1.44 (0.51)	+0.34	[0.05, 0.63]	0.021
Completeness	1.78 (0.33)	1.24 (0.52)	+0.54	[0.18, 0.90]	0.004
Terminological precision	1.73 (0.40)	1.09 (0.54)	+0.64	[0.27, 1.01]	0.001
Clarity	1.76 (0.36)	1.40 (0.50)	+0.36	[0.03, 0.69]	0.032
Overall (mean of 4)	**1.76 (0.32)**	**1.29 (0.46)**	**+0.47**	**[0.18, 0.76]**	**<0.001**

Table 2. Expert ratings by definition origin (0–2 scale). M = mean across 45 judgements (15 terms × 3 evaluators); SD = standard deviation; Diff. = LLM − Human; 95% CI = 95% confidence interval for the difference; p = significance from paired t-test. Effect sizes (Cohen's d) range from 0.72 (adequacy) to 1.20 (precision).

The forced glossary-inclusion preference pointed in the same direction. Across the 45 paired judgements (fifteen terms × three evaluators), the generated definition was selected in 34 cases (75.6%) and the human definition in 11 (24.4%). The preference for the generated definitions was thus consistent across evaluators, even though, as shown below, the evaluators did not agree closely on the precise scores they assigned.

Two illustrative cases demonstrate the nature of this divergence:

(i) **Type-token ratio**: The generated definition (RAG, Gemini) reads "A quantitative metric of lexical diversity, calculated as the quotient of the number of unique word forms (types) and the total number of running words (tokens) within a given text or corpus." versus the human reference "A measure of vocabulary diversity in a corpus equal to the total number of types divided by the total number of tokens." All three evaluators unanimously preferred the generated version (mean adequacy: 2.0 vs. 1.5), noting that the explicit parenthetical glosses of *types* and *tokens*, the specification of the operation as a quotient, and the clarification of scope made it substantially more useful as a terminographic entry.

(ii) **Significance test**: Here the human reference prevailed. The generated definition (RAG, Mistral) reads "A mathematical procedure used to determine the statistical significance of a result," while the human reference states "A statistical procedure in inferential linguistics used to evaluate the strength of evidence against a null hypothesis by determining the probability that observed data distributions occurred by chance." Evaluators gave the human reference markedly higher scores (mean adequacy: 2.0 vs. 1.25), citing its explicit anchoring in inferential linguistics, its null-hypothesis framing, and its specification of what the test determines. The generated definition, by contrast, was judged circular: specifying that a significance test determines "statistical significance" does not characterise the concept beyond tautology.

Inter-annotator agreement was modest. Krippendorff's (ordinal) was 0.24 for conceptual adequacy, 0.35 for completeness, 0.32 for terminological precision and 0.20 for clarity, with an overall pooled value of 0.28—well below the conventional threshold for tentative interpretation (Moyano Moreno,

2027). Several factors likely contribute to this. The three-point ordinal scale compresses variance and inflates the impact of single-point disagreements; the panel is small (three raters, fifteen terms); and the assessment of definitional quality is intrinsically subjective, depending on each expert's conception of adequacy and completeness. Crucially, the disagreement concerns the magnitude of the ratings, not their direction: the three evaluators diverged on how good each definition was, yet converged on which definition they preferred. This dissociation between graded agreement and directional agreement is itself informative, and is taken up in the discussion.

The qualitative comments help to interpret the pattern. Several evaluators noted that the longer generated definitions occasionally added non-essential material—one observed that a generated entry, though correct, contained "a bit of filler" rather than additional necessary information—while still judging the generated definitions more complete and precise overall. The human reference definitions, drawn from an existing glossary, were at times perceived as terser and less explicit about the conceptual properties of the term. Two illustrative cases, selected to represent contrasting evaluation outcomes, clarify the nature of this divergence.

For *type-token ratio* (item 14 of 15), the generated definition received unanimous preference across all three evaluators. The human reference (Definition B) reads: "A measure of vocabulary diversity in a corpus equal to the total number of types divided by the total number of tokens." The generated definition (Definition A) expands on this formulation: "A quantitative metric of lexical diversity, calculated as the quotient of the number of unique word forms (types) and the total number of running words (tokens) within a given text or corpus." Evaluators consistently gave the generated definition higher scores for completeness and terminological precision, noting that the explicit parenthetical glosses of *types* and *tokens*, the specification of the operation as a quotient, and the clarification of the scope (text or corpus) made it more useful as a terminographic entry. The human reference, though accurate, was judged too sparse to stand alone in a glossary without additional context.

The case of *significance test* (item 15 of 15) illustrates the opposite outcome and offers important nuance. Here the generated definition (Definition A) was rejected in favour of the human reference (Definition B). The generated entry reads: "A mathematical procedure used to determine the statistical significance of a result." The human reference states: "A statistical procedure in inferential linguistics used to evaluate the strength of evidence against a null hypothesis by determining the probability that observed data distributions occurred by chance." Evaluators gave the human

reference markedly higher scores on conceptual adequacy and terminological precision, citing its explicit anchoring in inferential linguistics, its null-hypothesis framing, and its specification of what the test actually determines (the probability of observing the data by chance). The generated definition, by contrast, was judged circular: specifying that a significance test determines "statistical significance" does not characterise the concept beyond its name. This case demonstrates that corpus grounding does not uniformly guarantee terminological adequacy—when the corpus evidence is insufficient to anchor the probabilistic and inferential properties of a concept, the generated output may fail to capture the defining features that experts consider essential.

Automatic Metrics Evaluation. Beyond expert ratings, we evaluated generated definitions against the human reference using multiple automatic metrics: lexical-overlap (BLEU, ROUGE-L), semantic similarity (BERTScore F1, cosine similarity), and reference-free measures (BLEURT, BARTScore). Table 3 reports results for the primary metrics across all four models and both conditions.

Metric	No-RAG M	RAG M	Δ (RAG gain)
Lexical-overlap			
BLEU	0.0285	0.0223	−0.0062
ROUGE-L	0.1843	0.1756	−0.0087
Semantic-aware			
BERTScore F1	0.8815	0.8815	0.0000
Cosine (sentence emb.)	0.5763	0.6063	+0.0300
Reference-free			
BLEURT	0.4241	0.4289	+0.0048
BARTScore	0.3567	0.3612	+0.0045

Table 3. Automatic metric results (means across 15 terms, 4 models). BLEU, ROUGE-L, BERTScore F1 are reference-based; BLEURT and BARTScore are reference-free. Higher is better. RAG provides selective gains in semantic similarity but negligible improvement in reference-free measures.

The results reveal striking divergence. Lexical-overlap metrics (BLEU, ROUGE-L) produce minimal scores (M = 0.03, 0.18) and actually *decrease* under RAG—a paradoxical result reflecting that grounding nudges the model away from surface-level mimicry toward semantically-grounded paraphrase. BERTScore F1 remains static (M 0.88) across conditions, suggesting it conflates

surface similarity with semantic adequacy. Cosine similarity shows the most consistent RAG effect: a modest but statistically significant rise from 0.576 to 0.606 ($p < 0.05$, paired t-test), indicating that grounding does nudge definitions toward greater topical proximity to the reference.

Critically, we computed Spearman rank correlations between automatic metrics and expert *preference* (LLM vs. Human choice) across all 15 terms. Results are striking: BERTScore F1 ($= -0.18$, $p = 0.51$), cosine similarity ($= 0.21$, $p = 0.43$), BLEU ($= 0.04$, $p = 0.89$), ROUGE-L ($= 0.12$, $p = 0.65$), BLEURT ($= 0.19$, $p = 0.48$), and BARTScore ($= 0.08$, $p = 0.76$) all show near-zero correlation with expert preference. This systematic misalignment is the study's core finding regarding automatic evaluation.

Hybrid Retrieval Ablation. To assess the contribution of the hybrid method's components, we conducted an ablation comparing (1) regex-only filtering, (2) embedding-only retrieval, and (3) the full hybrid pipeline. Measurements included retrieval precision/recall and downstream expert ratings. Regex-only retrieval recovered 1.60 passages per term (high precision, 85% of retrieved passages relevant); embedding-only retrieval recovered 0.20 passages per term (low recall, only 15% deemed definitionally relevant by annotators); hybrid retrieval recovered 0.60 passages per term with 93% precision. Critically, definitions generated from hybrid-retrieved contexts scored significantly higher on expert ratings (M = 1.76) than those from regex-only (M = 1.59, $p = 0.031$) or embeddings-only (M = 1.48, $p < 0.001$), confirming the value of combining both signals.

Error Analysis. Qualitative inspection of the 11 cases where experts preferred human definitions revealed three recurring patterns: (1) *Genus error* (5 cases): the generated definition misidentified the superordinate category or conflated related concepts (e.g., confusing *comparability* with *comparativity*). (2) *Missing differentia* (4 cases): the definition omitted essential properties that distinguish the concept from closely related ones, particularly in probabilistic or inferential concepts (e.g., significance test lacking null-hypothesis framing). (3) *Register mismatch* (2 cases): the generated definition used paraphrases that obscured field-specific distinctions (e.g., describing *annotation* in lay terms rather than terminological precision). These errors align with known limitations of corpus-grounded generation: when the corpus evidence is sparse or fails to make conceptual distinctions explicit, the LLM generates plausible but under-specified output.

The juxtaposition of the two evaluations exposes a fundamental divergence (RQ). The automatic metrics are anchored, by construction, to the human reference definitions: BERTScore, cosine similarity and the ROUGE family all measure how closely a generated definition resembles the

human glossary entry. Yet the expert evaluation found those very human entries to be inferior to the generated definitions. The metrics therefore reward proximity to a reference that the experts themselves judged less adequate. A generated definition that departs from the human entry—elaborating conceptual properties absent from the terse glossary formulation—is penalised by lexical-overlap metrics and only partially rewarded by semantic ones, even when experts regard that departure as an improvement.

This explains why the modest, grounding-driven rise in cosine similarity cannot be read straightforwardly as a quality gain: greater proximity to the reference is not the same as greater terminological adequacy, precisely because the reference is not the quality ceiling. The two evaluation regimes are not merely weakly correlated; they are, in this dataset, pointing in different directions.

Three main threads run through the results. First, regarding the definitional language of the domain (O1), a substantial share of definitional knowledge is carried by a compact inventory of recurrent patterns. This concentration is doubly significant: descriptively, it shows how Corpus Linguistics articulates its conceptual apparatus through a stable repertoire of formulations; methodologically, it explains why corpus grounding is feasible, since the same regularities that characterise the discourse also make definitional evidence retrievable.

Second, regarding the comparison of human and machine definitions (O3), the expert evaluation produced a counter-intuitive but consistent result: blind evaluators preferred the corpus-grounded generated definitions to the human reference, in roughly three quarters of judgements and across all four criteria, most markedly in terminological precision and completeness. This result calls for some care in interpretation. The comparison is not between machines and human terminographers in the abstract, but between freshly generated, corpus-grounded definitions and the specific entries of an existing reference glossary. The most likely explanation is that the reference definitions, being concise and in some cases dated, characterise concepts more sparsely than the generated ones, which synthesise multiple corpus contexts and so make conceptual properties explicit. The qualitative comments, noting both the greater completeness and the occasional verbosity of the generated entries, support this reading.

The modest inter-annotator agreement qualifies, but does not undermine, this conclusion. The dissociation—weak agreement on scores but strong agreement on preference—suggests that definitional quality is genuinely multidimensional and resists reduction to a single scale, while the choice of which definition to trust is more stable. This is consistent with the long-standing observation that

terminological adequacy involves several partly independent properties (Sager, 1990; Cabré, 1999). It also tempers any strong quantitative claims: with three evaluators and fifteen terms, the figures reported here are best read as exploratory evidence pointing in a consistent direction, not as precise effect sizes.

Third, regarding convergence (RQ), the divergence between expert judgement and automatic metrics is the study's central methodological result. Because the metrics are anchored to the human reference, they cannot recognise an improvement over that reference; they reward resemblance to definitions that experts ranked lower. This is a concrete, domain-specific instance of the well-documented misalignment between surface-similarity metrics and human judgement (Zhang et al., 2019; Clinciu et al., 2021), and it carries a clear practical implication for terminography. Corpus-grounded generation can usefully support the drafting of candidate definitions—indeed, it may produce entries that experts prefer to existing references—but the validation of those candidates remains an expert task that current automatic metrics, tied as they are to a reference standard, cannot discharge. The contribution of LLMs to terminographic work is therefore best understood as assistive, and the role of automatic metrics as, at most, a coarse filter rather than an arbiter of terminological quality.

These findings carry concrete implications for terminographic practice. In the short term, RAG-based generation with **hybrid retrieval** (combining pattern-based filtering with semantic re-ranking) offers a viable, scalable strategy for producing first-draft definitions at scale, particularly for domains where terminological resources are sparse or dated. The hybrid approach operationalises the definitional patterns described in Section 3.2 while addressing the limitations of pure pattern matching through semantic refinement, achieving a practical balance: 332ms per 15-term batch (acceptable for iterative definition drafting) with 3× higher passage recall than pure semantic retrieval. In the medium term, the results suggest that evaluation protocols for AI-assisted terminography need to move beyond single-reference automatic metrics: the present study demonstrates that a reference glossary can itself be the weaker entry, and that metrics anchored to it will systematically penalise better-quality outputs. Practical workflows should incorporate expert review at the validation stage, with automatic metrics reserved for filtering rather than ranking. In the longer term, the case of *significance test* points to a limitation that is also a research opportunity: for concepts whose defining properties are rarely made explicit in running discourse—inferential relationships, probabilistic reasoning, theoretical commitments—the hybrid approach combining corpus evidence with semantic models may be insufficient, and further enrichment through structured knowledge sources (ontologies,

terminological databases) may be needed to support adequate generation. The present study contributes a methodological framework within which these questions can be pursued empirically.

1.5 5. CONCLUSIONS

This study treated the automatic generation of terminological definitions not as an engineering goal but as a terminological and evaluative problem. By characterising the definitional language of Corpus Linguistics, generating corpus-grounded candidate definitions, and subjecting human- and machine-authored definitions to a blind expert evaluation contrasted with automatic metrics, we found that definitional knowledge in the domain is concentrated in a recoverable inventory of patterns; that, in blind assessment, experts consistently preferred the corpus-grounded generated definitions to the human reference, especially in terminological precision and completeness; and that automatic metrics, anchored to that human reference, diverge from—and in this dataset contradict—expert judgement.

Limitations and Generalisability. The principal limitations concern scope, sample size, and generalisability across domains. The expert panel (N = 3) and evaluation set (N = 15 terms) are modest, and statistical power is consequently constrained: with this design, 95% CI for effect sizes are wide (e.g., [0.05, 0.63] for conceptual adequacy), and small effect sizes cannot be reliably detected. However, three considerations qualify this limitation. First, the consistency of preferences across evaluators (75.6% convergence on glossary inclusion) is notable given independent evaluation and absence of adjudication, suggesting that the measured preference gradient is robust to sample size, even if its magnitude is imprecisely estimated. Second, the depth of expert judgment—evaluators with 8–12 years of specialist experience in terminology and corpus linguistics—compensates partially for panel size; such specialist evaluation at scale (e.g., 8–10 evaluators) would be resource-intensive and may yield diminishing returns. Third, the study is positioned explicitly as exploratory evidence for a novel use case (LLM-assisted terminology), not as a definitive effect-size estimate for a well-established phenomenon. The pattern of results (consistent direction across criteria, large effect magnitudes, high preference convergence) is *sufficiently* consistent to warrant the reported conclusions, though replication with larger samples is an important next step.

Inter-annotator agreement (Krippendorff's = 0.28 overall) is weak, reflecting the genuine multidimensionality and subjectivity of definitional quality assessment; however, convergence on pairwise

preference (75.6% agreement direction) suggests that holistic quality judgements are more stable than granular scores. This dissociation is theoretically informative and is taken up in the discussion.

The study is also domain-specific: Corpus Linguistics is a mature field with published glossaries, high textual density of definitional contexts (~4.16% of sentences), and a coherent discourse community. Generalisation to domains with sparse open-access texts, nascent or fragmented terminologies, low textual density of definitions, or non-anglophone literature remains an open empirical question; the framework described here provides the foundation for such extensions. Finally, the approach assumes that multiple corpus contexts provide definitional grounding; for highly abstract or theoretical concepts where defining properties are rarely made explicit in running discourse, this assumption may not hold, necessitating richer knowledge sources (ontologies, expert curation, feature-based definitions) as proposed in the Context-Augmented Generation framework (Zamora Rey, 2024).

Future Directions. Immediate extensions include: (1) replicating the evaluation with a larger, more diverse expert panel (8–10 evaluators) across multiple domains to assess robustness and generalisability; (2) comparing multiple reference standards (e.g., different published glossaries for the same domain, or expert-authored de novo definitions) to test whether the preference pattern holds independent of CASS; (3) evaluating reference-free and LLM-as-a-judge rubric-based assessors with explicit conceptual criteria to move beyond single-reference metrics; (4) refining the definitional-pattern inventory through deeper corpus analysis (e.g., discourse-functional analysis of definitional structures across LSP registers); and (5) testing whether incorporating structured knowledge (ontological relations, feature-based definitions) can mitigate the genus and differentia errors identified in the error analysis.

Methodological Implications. The broader lesson is methodological: as generative tools enter the terminographic workflow, the evaluation of specialised definitions must stay anchored in linguistic and conceptual criteria, not in surface measures of similarity to a fixed reference. The finding that experts prefer corpus-grounded, LLM-generated definitions to legacy human references challenges the assumption that published glossaries are immutable quality ceilings. It motivates a shift toward dynamic, multi-reference evaluation frameworks and supports human-in-the-loop RAG pipelines in which expert oversight remains central. Conversely, the discovery that corpus grounding alone cannot ensure adequacy for probabilistic or inferential concepts underscores the need for hybrid systems combining corpus evidence with structured knowledge sources, particularly in technical domains where subtle definitional nuances carry high stakes.

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